

Topic Input: Demographics



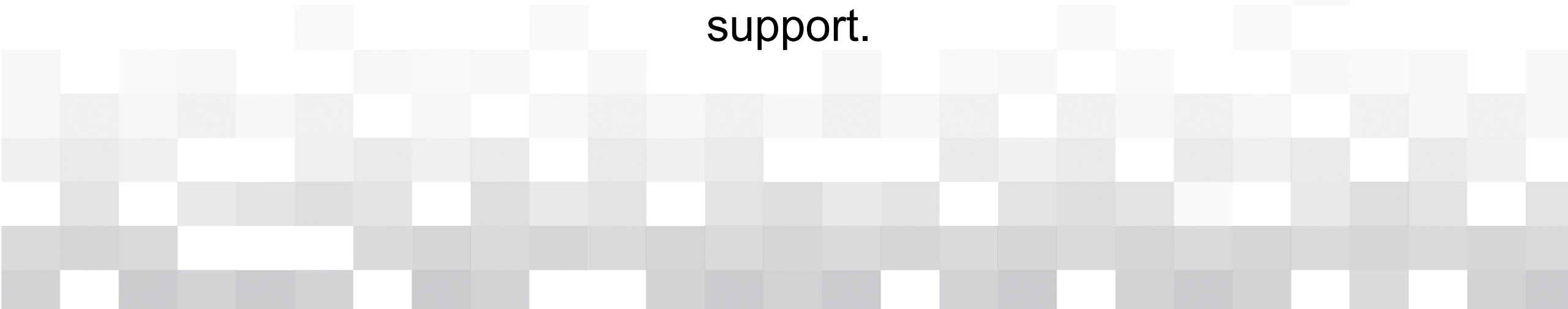
THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

This week the topic is demographics.

...the statistical study of human population...

[Demography \(nationalgeographic.org\)](http://nationalgeographic.org)

One debate centres around how many people the Earth can support.

A decorative pattern at the bottom of the slide consisting of a grid of squares in various shades of gray, creating a pixelated or mosaic effect.

In the 1960s, fears of overpopulation sparked campaigns for population control. But whatever became of the population bomb?

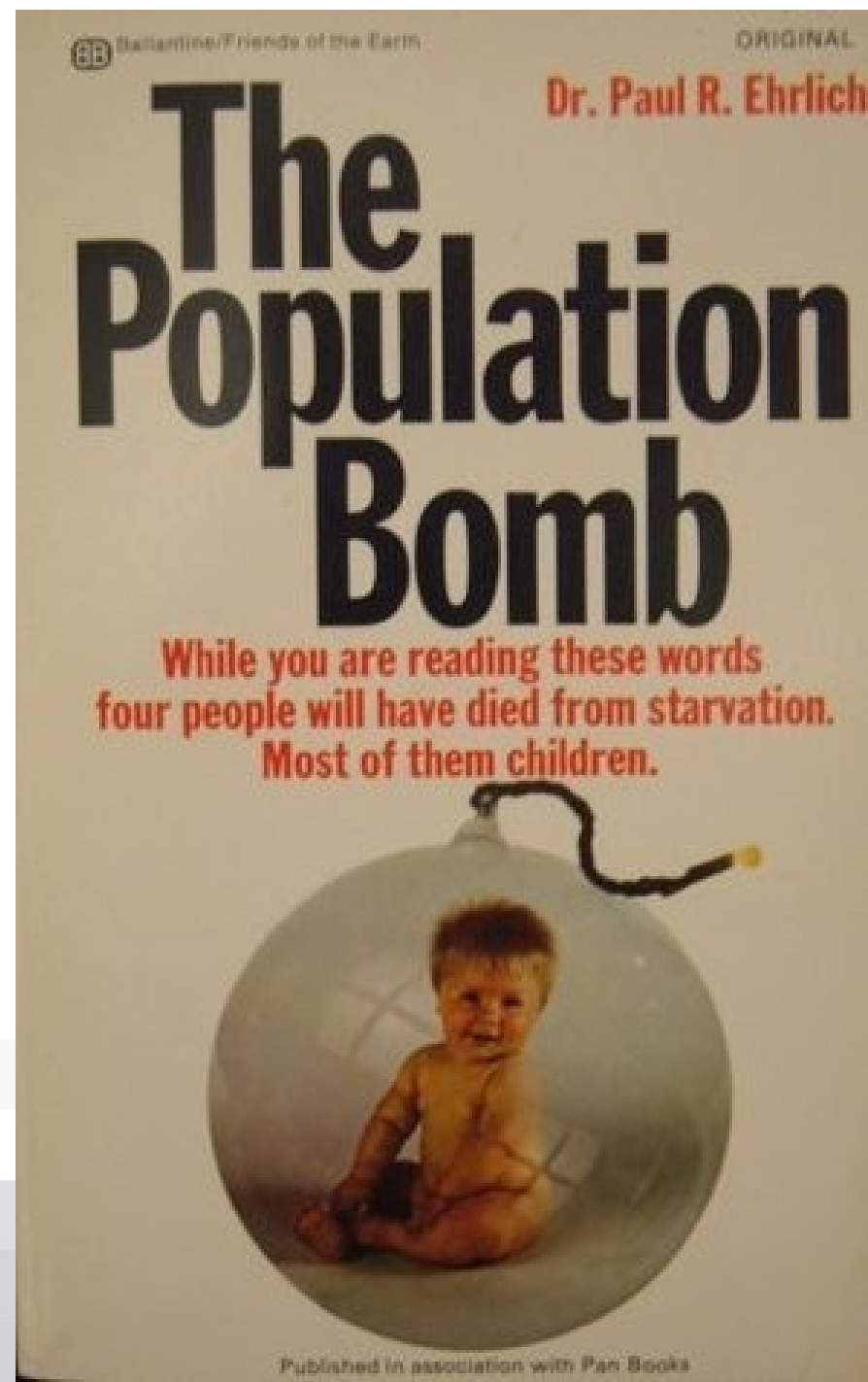
Watch [the video from the New York Times](#) and answer these questions:

- Who was Paul Ehrlich and what did he believe?
- Were his predictions correct?
- Why have fertility rates decreased in India?
- What is the 'flip-side' of a population explosion?



Who was Paul Ehrlich?

An American biologist who wrote a book called “The Population Bomb” in the 1970s.



What did he believe?



“Some time in the next 15 years,
the end will come, and by the
end I mean an utter
breakdown of the capacity of
the planet to support
humanity”

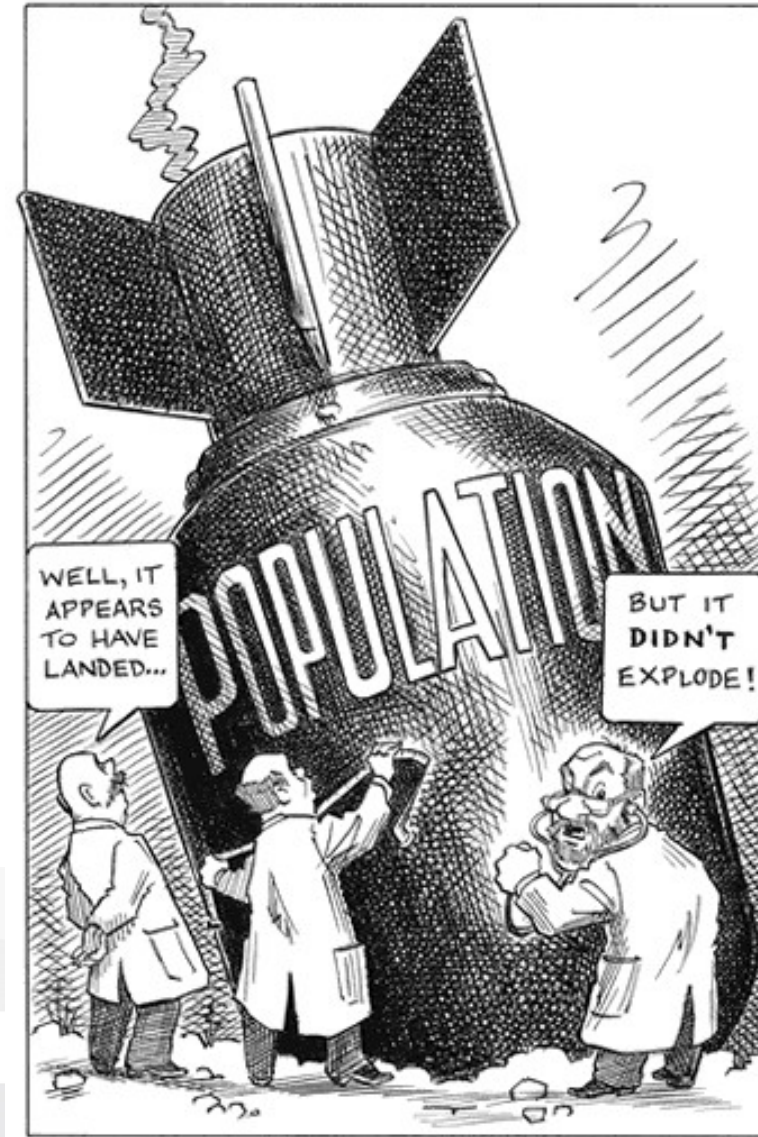
– Paul Ehrlich speaking in 1970



Was he right?

NO

1. The “end” of the planet did not come in 1985 as he predicted
2. His prediction that England would not exist in the year 2000 was not correct
3. His prediction that India would be starving by the 1970s was not correct



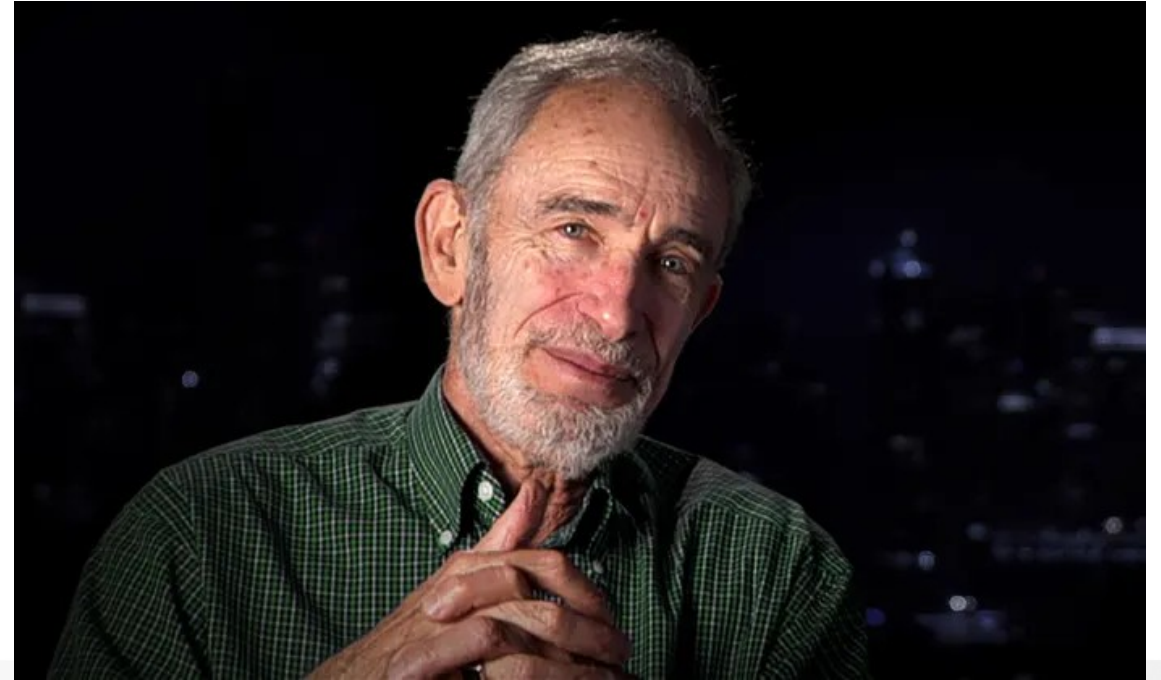
But...



Ehrlich still believes *“it is just a matter of time”*.

He says:

“I do not believe my language was too apocalyptic in the Population Bomb. My language would be even more apocalyptic today”.



Why have fertility rates decreased in India?



1. Large families once needed for farming are no longer seen as the key to success
2. Fertility rates have been reduced by sterilisation
3. Fertility rates have also been reduced by a focus on maternal health and reduction of infant mortality

Should we be more concerned about population implosion?



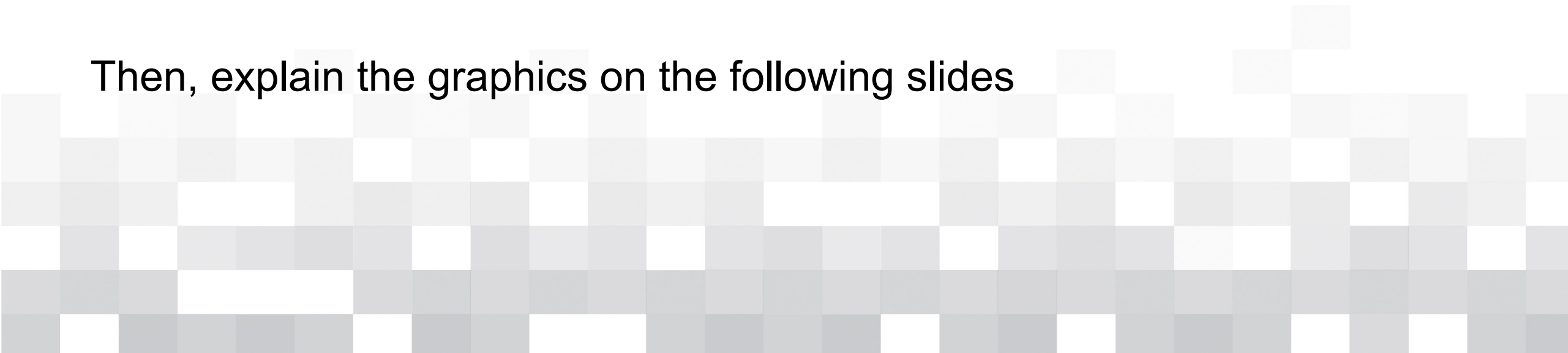
Population Collapse

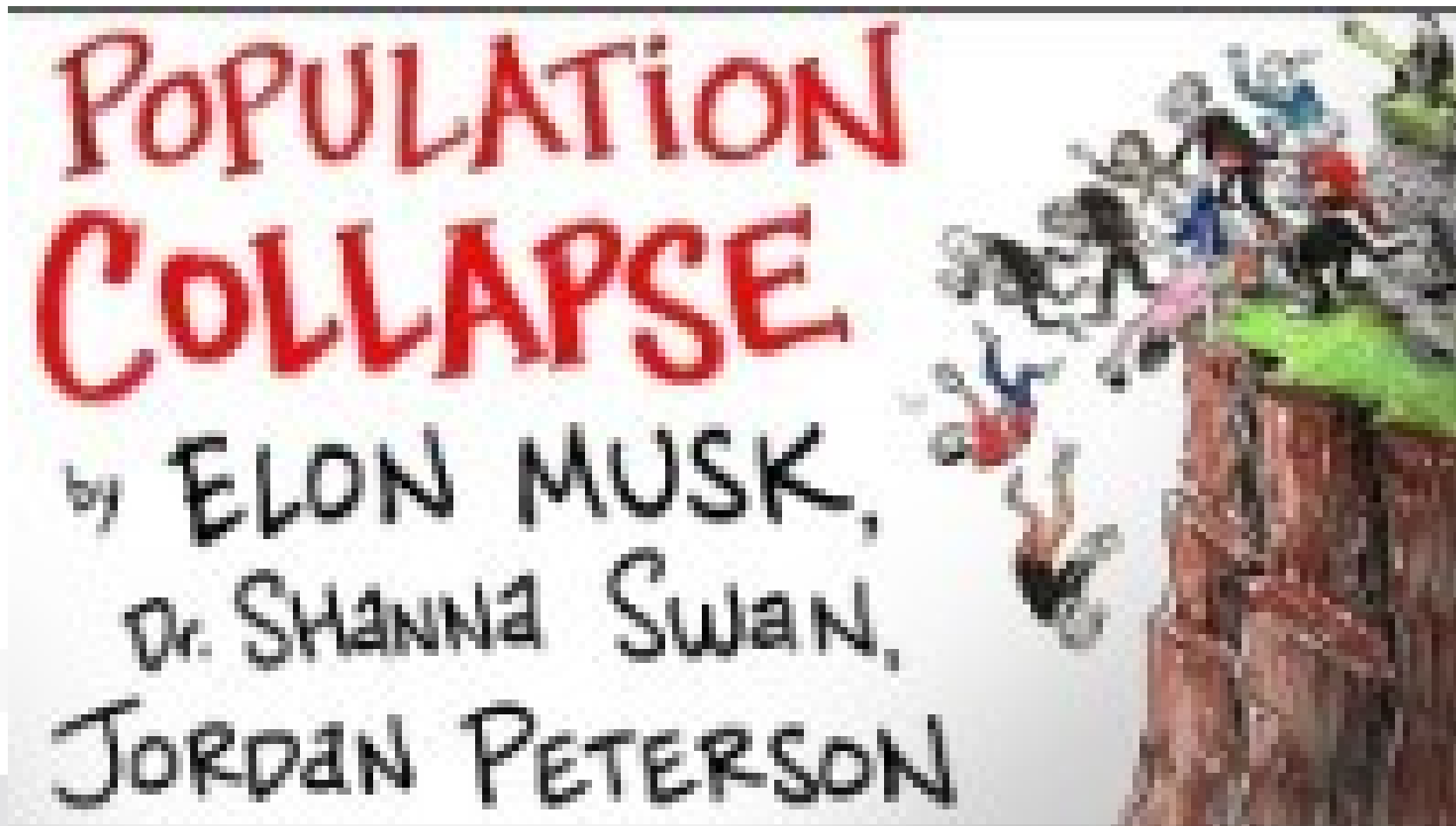


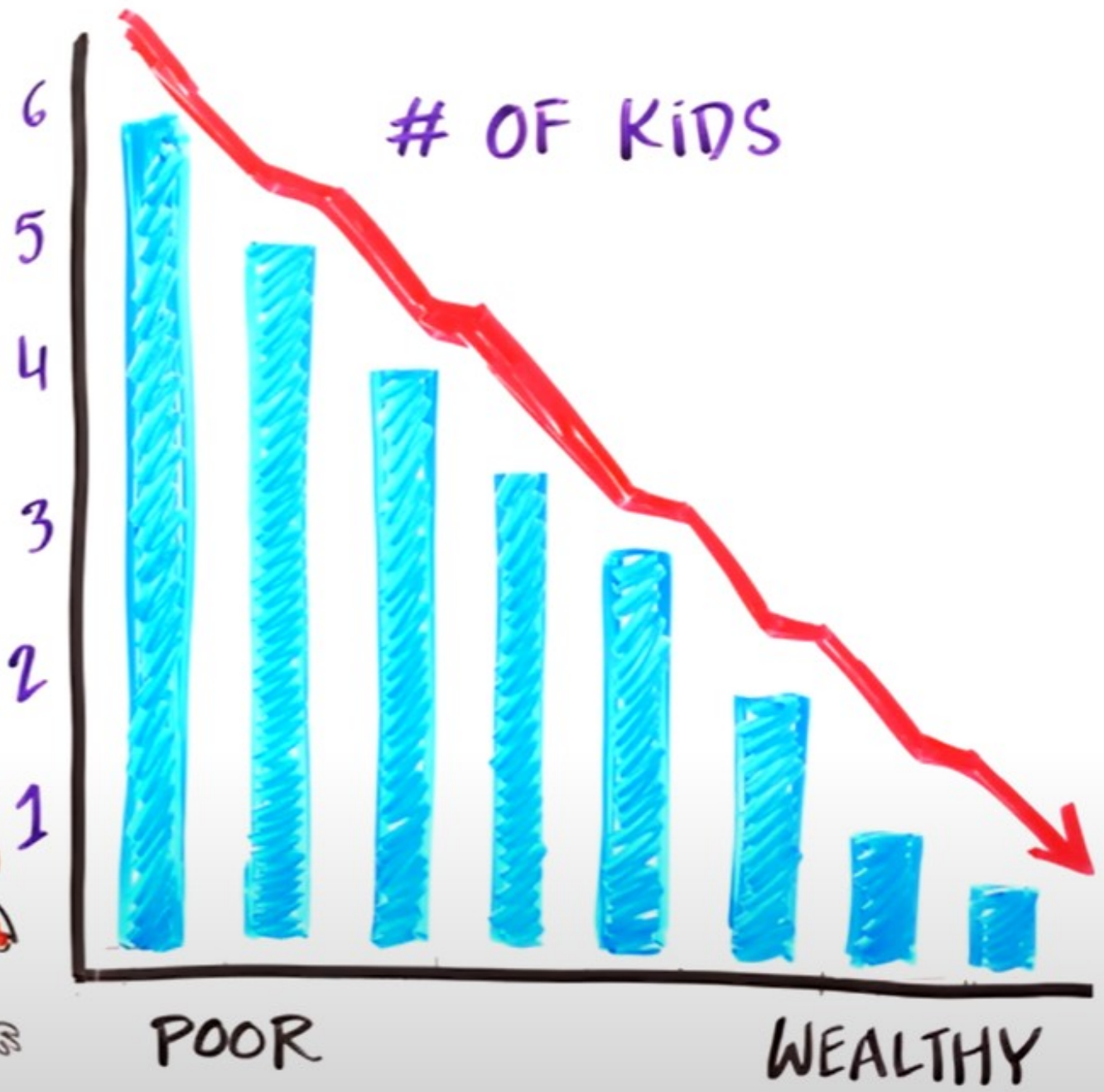
Watch these two speakers discuss [population decline](#)
(*end video at 4 mins 35*)

- Elon Musk
- Dr. Shanna Swan

Then, explain the graphics on the following slides





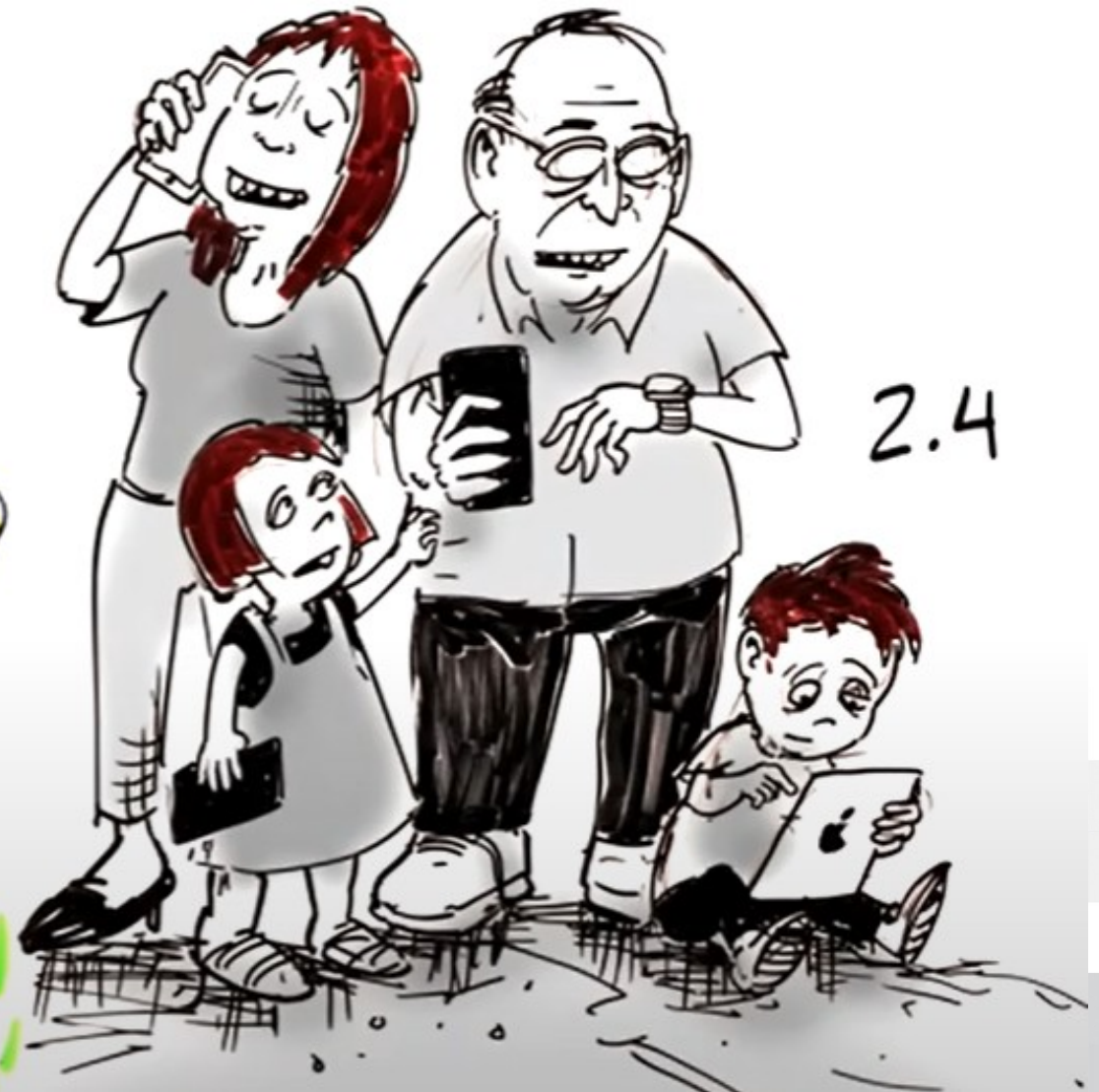


1960's

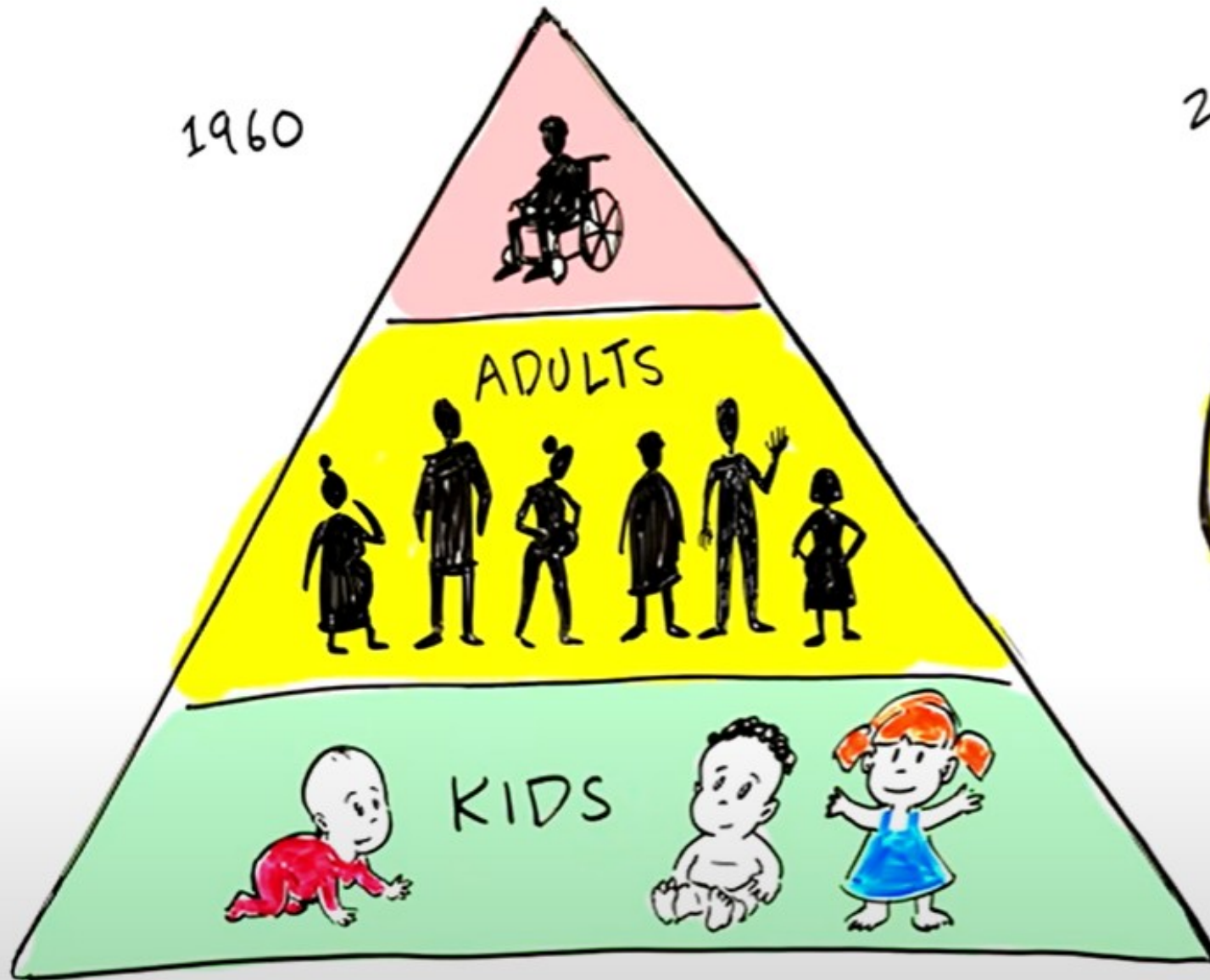
TODAY

5

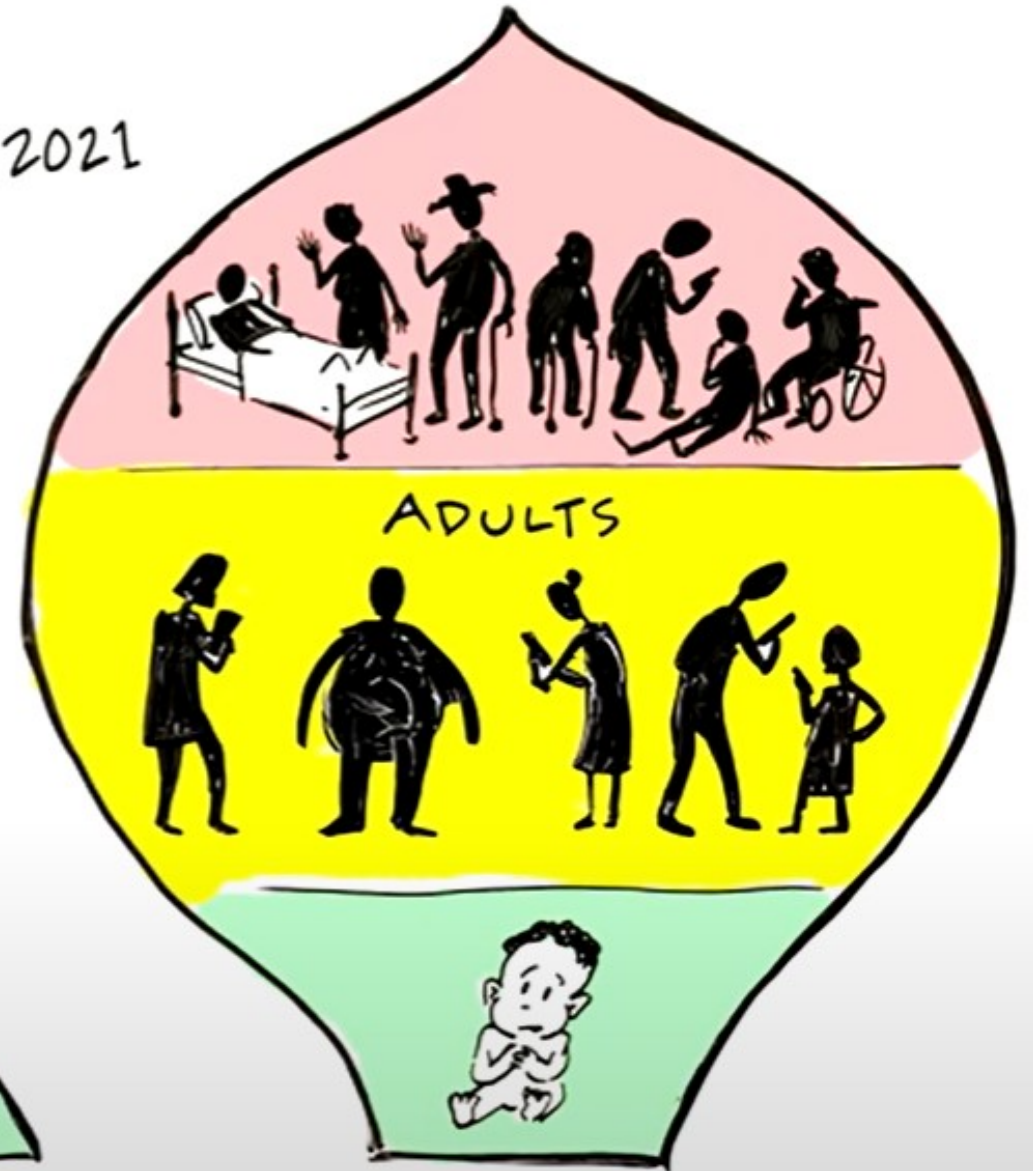
2.4



1960



2021



Population Game



Use the online 'population game' to find out:

- a) How many people were on the planet when you were born
- b) How many children were born in the same year as you
- c) What percentage of the world are older/younger than you

Share your answers with a partner.



What is the situation in your country?

- Is there concern about population? If so, what is the concern?
- Does your government have any policies to increase/decrease population? If so, what are the policies?
- What issues occur when a country is overpopulated & what issues occur when a country is underpopulated?
- Would you rather live in a country that was overpopulated or underpopulated? Why?